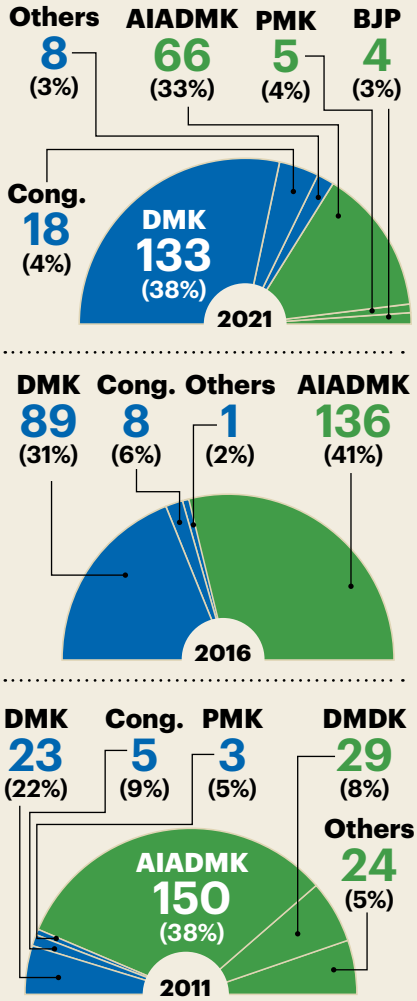


In its essence, the 2026 assembly election in Tamil Nadu is a battle to build legacies. On the one side is the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and its 73-year-old chief minister M.K. Stalin, who is attempting a remarkable feat for his party, a second consecutive term in power. On the other is their traditional rival, the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) and its general secretary, Edappadi K. Palaniswami (EPS). For EPS, this is not just a battle to establish himself as a leader in his own right; it is also one to resurrect a party that has been braving many a storm since the death of its iconic leader, the late J. Jayalalithaa, in 2016.

The contest itself is unfolding in a political landscape that is more fragmented and less predictable than at any point in recent years. While it continues to be framed as a familiar battle between the DMK and the AIADMK, shifts beneath the surface point to a more complicated, tripolar contest. The complication comes in the guise of superstar Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), which is positioning itself as an independent alternative to the two Dravidian majors. The TVK's presence could disrupt established vote patterns, particularly among disaffected younger sections and urban voters, which, in turn, could rock the calculations of more than a few players on D-day, April 23, when the state goes to vote.

PAST BATTLES

Total seats: **234**



DMK-led coalition AIADMK-led coalition

Coloured numbers denote seats won; vote share in ()

ZONES OF CONTEST

✪Dominant groups, % of population in region

❖Key issues

Total assembly seats

DMK+ won

AIADMK+ won

WESTERN REGION (Kongu Nadu)

Coimbatore, Tiruppur, Erode, Salem, Namakkal, Dharmapuri, Krishnagiri, Nilgiris

✪Gounders (Kongu Vellalar): 25-30%; Arunthathiyars (SC subgroup): 8-10%; Muslims & others: 6-8%

❖Slow industrial growth, price rise affecting small industries (textiles, knitwear); unemployment and migration; roads

2021 results: **68** | **24** | **44**



History Beckons

The ruling DMK is hoping to break a jinx this election. The party has only once been voted back to power for a consecutive second term, and that was way back in 1971. Even the party patriarch, the late M. Karunanidhi, could not repeat the feat. It's a pattern that his son Stalin, chief minister and DMK president, is determined to break this election.

The party entered the 2026 Tamil Nadu election season with what appears to be a carefully constructed strategy: a broad alliance, early organisational preparation, an attempt to recast itself in a more modern, youthful light, and some concentrated booth-level mobilisation.

The DMK started poll preparations well in advance, in early 2025, with Stalin reviewing all the major welfare schemes that come under the party's 'Naan Mudhalvan (I am First)' project. As has been the practice of all election-bound governments these past few years, the CM also ensured that all beneficiaries got their dues much before the poll dates were notified. Another small residue of being in power—anti-incumbency—was also addressed: a shake-up of the legislature party was deemed the answer—there are 60 new faces among the 164 candidates it is fielding.

The DMK also sewed up a far-ranging coalition, bringing in new partners while retaining older ones. This had